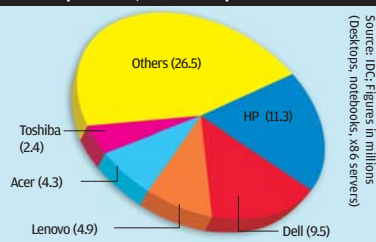




Stat Attack

It's all in the numbers

Top five vendors, worldwide PC shipments, second quarter 2007



The number of active Internet users in India had increased to 60 lakh by March 2007 vs. 41.2 lakh a year before

Half of 25 to 34-year-olds in the UK would not be able to "carry on" without e-mail. More women (41%) than men (38%) were hooked to their Inbox

Desktop PC sales in India increased 19% in 2006-07 over the previous financial year. Notebook sales, a whopping 97%

Half of the 24 million homes in the US with HDTVs lack an HD cable or satellite feed. A quarter didn't even know they were still watching non-HD signals!

that using the cheesy "laser" sound effect makes for a "cool, dynamic" look... the list is endless.

Seriously, though, it's a good move. B-school students we know have also confirmed that one of the first and most important skills they learn while within those walls is to make good presentations. Your projects are worthless if you don't have the presentation summarising it, so it's only logical that your application should include something similar. We're just waiting for our Indian B-schools to follow suit. Maybe then this era of PowerPoint abuse will finally end.

THEY DO RESEARCH, TOO

Beyond Windows And Word

Microsoft, known rather more popularly for Windows and Office, recently bundled four applications into a design suite called Expression Studio. It comprises Expression Web, Expression Blend, Expression Design, and Expression Media. These tools work together for Web and Desktop applications to support Silverlight (which

we've spoken about in this space) and the .NET platform. What's interesting here is that this is significantly indicative of the fact that Microsoft is seriously looking at research, cutting-edge research beyond what we call mundane. (It takes a horizontal shift of thought to realise that research goes into operating systems, too.)

Whenever there's a mention about research in computer graphics, a few names are always at the top of the list—Adobe, Industrial Light & Magic, and, as if we need to mention it, NVIDIA. At SIGGRAPH 2007, Microsoft researchers presented one of every eight papers on industrial computer graphics. (SIGGRAPH is an international conference around research in computer graphics and interactive technologies; it is held every year, and have been active for more than three decades.)

Richard Szeliski, head of the interactive visual media group at Microsoft Research, said, "What we produce is of the same quality and calibre as the best universities in the world." The latest from the Microsoft Research stables includes image de-blurring software, which combines pictures blurred due to camera shake and reconstitutes them into a single high-quality image. Szeliski says the software can improve images taken even from a 1MP phone camera. So you'll be able to take a lot of bad pictures and use them to produce one good one!

Then there's Soft Scissors, which cuts an image with complex edges from one background to another—in real-time, on a regular PC.

For instance, you can add a picture of a pet to the family portrait using Soft Scissors. The outline of the pet could involve fur, and Soft Scissors' algorithm can deal even with such complex edges.

Enthusiasts and professional digital photographers will make the best use of such tools.

Mind you, Microsoft Research isn't the only set of teams out there working on such algorithms. But most research isn't productised, and Microsoft has the edge because, well, they're in the business of selling software.

An interesting issue here is copyright... if image enhancing tools such as these are made available to the public at large, then imagine the following: an enemy could pick up a portrait of yours and mess around with it. You could end up looking ridiculous. But it's been morphed beyond recognition, so it would be tough for you to claim it's *your* picture... and would you want to make that claim?

There is also speculation about whether the algorithms and final products Microsoft Research comes out with will be commercialised—or remain interesting online pastimes. But remember there's a "\$" in "M\$".

PROTECTION NEEDS PATCHING

Safe In The Knowledge

The last piece of software on your computer to have a security vulnerability would

Buzzword of the MONTH

Sandtiger

AMD has revealed its plans to release, in 2009, an eight-core chip code-named Sandtiger. AMD hopes that this new offering, coupled with its quad-core Barcelona and Shanghai (for its second-generation Opteron platform) processors, will tip the scales in its favour—with Intel on the other side, of course. Sandtiger will have an inbuilt memory controller and eight "Bulldozer" cores built using the 45nm fabrication

technology. It will be at the heart of AMD's third-generation Opteron platform.

Aimed at the high-end server and workstation segments, Sandtiger incorporates a slew of new technologies like HyperTransport 3.0 (which links individual cores) and Direct Connect 2 (which improves system speed and efficiency). Sandtiger will also support DDR3 memory.

Does Intel care about Sandtiger? Will it? We'll have to wait for 2009...